MODULE 33 · ALL DOMAINS

How the Questions Are Written

The anatomy of an item, the qualifiers that decide between workable options, the ten rules as tiebreakers, the eleven distractor families, choose-two and explain items, and pacing.

DOMAINS All 8 ITEMS 53 in 120 min MODULE 33 of 36

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A detective reads the whole scene before naming a suspect. **The stem is the scene. The clue that clears three options is already in it.**

The anatomy of an item

01
Scenario
A team, a system, a symptom or a goal.

02
Constraints
Cost, latency, data rules, who waits, what exists.

03
Qualifier
First, best, most cost-effective, least effort.

04
Options
One key; three real features in the wrong place.

05
Count
Choose one, or the stated number.

THE HABIT

Read the last sentence first. It tells you what kind of answer to look for.

Qualifiers decide between workable options

QUALIFIER	WHAT IT ASKS	USUALLY PICKS
First, first step	The earliest correct action	Evidence or requirements
Best, most appropriate	The fullest fit to every stated need	The complete answer
Most cost-effective	The cheapest option that still meets the need	Smaller tier, batch, caching
Least effort or overhead	Fewest parts to build and run	The platform feature
Most reliable or secure	Deterministic over probable	Code checks, least privilege

ON THE EXAM

Several options often work. The qualifier says which one the question wants.

The rules as tiebreakers: one to five

RULE	PICKS THE OPTION THAT	BEATS
1. Code enforces, prompts guide	Checks a must-always rule in code	Prompt as enforcement
2. Evidence before change	Reads traces or evals first	Model swaps, dials
3. Requirement first	Defines the need, then chooses	Over-engineering
4. The complete answer	Covers every stated need	The partial answer
5. Use what the platform gives	Uses the built-in feature	Rebuilds, custom training

THE TIEBREAKER

When two options both seem right, ask which rule the question is testing.

The rules as tiebreakers: six to ten

RULE	PICKS THE OPTION THAT	BEATS
6. Small, tested steps	Stages and tests the change	Big-bang change
7. Failure is a designed path	Retries, repairs, falls back	Accept it, push to users
8. Keep context lean	Prunes, pins, isolates	A bigger model or window
9. Variation is a property	Validates and structures output	Sampling dials, training
10. Least privilege	Narrows keys, tools, permissions	Removing the control

THE TIEBREAKER

Most wrong options fail exactly one rule. Name the rule, and the option falls.

Distractor families: one to six

FAMILY	SOUNDS LIKE	WHY IT LOSES
Remove the control	"Turn off the slow check"	Fixes the pain, loses the protection
Push it to users	"Ask users to rephrase"	Your problem, their effort
Prompt as enforcement	"Add a stronger instruction"	Guidance, not a guarantee
Over-engineering	"Build a multi-agent framework"	More parts than the need
Big-bang change	"Switch everything on Friday"	No evidence, no way back
Permanent avoidance	"Stop using the feature"	Abandons a fixable design

THE TRAP

Each family is tempting because it really would make the symptom go away.

Distractor families: seven to eleven

FAMILY	SOUNDS LIKE	WHY IT LOSES
Accept the problem	"Models just do that"	Leaves a known fault in place
Swap the model	"Use the biggest model"	Hides the cause; costs more
The partial answer	Two of three needs met	The complete answer wins
Train a custom model	"Fine-tune it"	Prompts, examples, evals first
Turn a sampling dial	"Lower the temperature"	Rejected now; never the fix

THE TRAP

The partial answer is the hardest: every word in it is true. Count the needs it covers.

Choose-two and explain items

- **Choose two:** each pick must be right on its own. Two options that overlap are rarely both keys.
- **Pairs are often two layers:** a control plus monitoring, a design plus disclosure.
- **Explain to a teammate:** pick the statement that is true and gives the reason.
- **Watch for true but irrelevant:** a correct fact that does not answer this question.
- **Never infer the count:** the item states it. Select exactly that many.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> In explain items, the right option teaches. The wrong ones reassure, exaggerate or blame.

Pacing: 53 items in 120 minutes

- **About 2 min 15 s per item.** Most take less; long scenarios take more.
- **First pass:** answer what you can, flag what you cannot settle in about three minutes.
- **Second pass:** return to flags with the time you banked.
- **Answer every item.** A blank cannot score.
- **Change an answer only for a reason** you can name, such as a missed constraint.

> THE HABIT
>
> Time pressure makes the familiar fix look right. Slow down on the qualifier, not the options.

> A product owner asks for a Claude feature that summarises recorded sales calls for account managers.
>
> Nothing has been built yet.

What should the developer do first?

A Agree success criteria and collect sample calls

B Build it on the most capable model available

C Build an agent with access to the CRM and email

D Fine-tune a model on past call summaries

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the developer do first?

A Agree success criteria and collect sample calls
Requirement first.

B Build it on the most capable model available
Swap the model, before any need.

C Build an agent with access to the CRM and email
Over-engineering.

D Fine-tune a model on past call summaries
Train a custom model.

THE SIGNAL

"First" with nothing built means requirements. Rule 3 beats three familiar families.

> A product manager asks why the team will not just add "NEVER reveal other customers' data" in capitals to the system prompt and ship.
>
> You are asked to explain.

Which explanation should you give?

A Capitals are reliable on current models, so it would be enough

B Larger models ignore capitals, so it needs a smaller model

C A prompt guides; a must-always rule needs a check in code

D The instruction must be repeated in every user message

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which explanation should you give?

A Capitals are reliable on current models, so it would be enough

Prompt as enforcement.

B Larger models ignore capitals, so it needs a smaller model

False, and swaps the model.

C A prompt guides; a must-always rule needs a check in code

True, and gives the reason.

D The instruction must be repeated in every user message

Still only a prompt.

THE SIGNAL

Explain items reward the statement that is true and teaches the principle behind it.

> A nightly job classifies about 50,000 support emails by topic for a morning report. Evals show Haiku 5.5 meets the accuracy target.
>
> Nobody reads the results until 9am.

Which approach is most cost-effective?

A Opus in real time, for the highest accuracy

B Haiku through the Message Batches API overnight

C Sonnet in real time, with fast mode turned on

D Haiku in real time, with prompt caching on

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which approach is most cost-effective?

A Opus in real time, for the highest accuracy
Pays for accuracy not required.

B Haiku through the Message Batches API overnight
Smallest tier, half price.

C Sonnet in real time, with fast mode turned on
Pays twice for speed nobody needs.

D Haiku in real time, with prompt caching on
Works, but costs more than B.

THE SIGNAL

"Most cost-effective": B and D both work. The qualifier picks the cheaper one that meets the need.

> A payments assistant's replies must be valid JSON for the app, follow the company tone guide, and never contain a card number.
>
> The team is choosing a design.

Which design is best?

A Structured outputs from a schema, and nothing else

B The tone guide and the card-number rule in the prompt

C Structured outputs, plus a card-number check in code

D Schema, tone guide in the prompt, card check in code

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which design is best?

A Structured outputs from a schema, and nothing else

Covers one need of three.

B The tone guide and the card-number rule in the prompt

Prompt as enforcement for cards.

C Structured outputs, plus a card-number check in code

Two of three: no tone guide.

D Schema, tone guide in the prompt, card check in code

All three needs, each at its layer.

THE SIGNAL

Count the needs in the stem, then count them in each option. The complete answer wins.

> A team must move 30 prompt templates to a new model before the old one retires in eight weeks.
>
> Each template has an owner, and most have an eval set.

Which two belong in the plan? Choose two.

A Switch all thirty templates together on retirement day

B Migrate in batches, each validated against its evals

C Rewrite every prompt from scratch before testing anything

D Baseline every template on the current model first

E Skip evals for low-traffic templates to save time

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two belong in the plan? Choose two.

A Switch all thirty templates together on retirement day

Big-bang change.

B Migrate in batches, each validated against its evals

Small, tested steps.

C Rewrite every prompt from scratch before testing anything

Change before evidence.

D Baseline every template on the current model first

Evidence before change.

E Skip evals for low-traffic templates to save time

The partial answer.

THE SIGNAL

Two layers again: evidence first, then staged change. Each pick stands on its own.

> A Claude Code hook blocks edits to the database migrations folder. It runs a full repository scan on every edit, adding a few seconds each time.
>
> Engineers propose removing it.

What should the team do?

A Narrow the hook to migrations paths, and make it fast

B Remove the hook, as the engineers propose

C Ask engineers to edit migrations outside Claude Code

D Replace the hook with a note in the project memory file

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the team do?

A Narrow the hook to migrations paths, and make it fast

Keeps the control, fixes the cost.

B Remove the hook, as the engineers propose

Remove the control.

C Ask engineers to edit migrations outside Claude Code

Push it to users; avoidance.

D Replace the hook with a note in the project memory file

Prompt as enforcement.

THE SIGNAL

When a control hurts, fix the control. Removing it is a family, not a fix.

> A support chat starts forgetting the customer's order number at around turn 30. Each turn carries the full history.
>
> A teammate proposes moving to the largest model.

What should the team do?

A Move to the largest model, as proposed

B Ask customers to start a new chat every twenty turns

C Pin the order details each turn; compact old turns

D Accept it, since long chats always drift

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the team do?

A Move to the largest model, as proposed

Swap the model.

B Ask customers to start a new chat every twenty turns

Push it to users.

C Pin the order details each turn; compact old turns

Keep context lean.

D Accept it, since long chats always drift

Accept the problem.

THE SIGNAL

Drift in a long chat is a context problem. Rule 8 beats the model swap.

> An extraction feature's output format varies between runs, breaking a parser about once in fifty calls.
>
> Teammates propose either fine-tuning a custom model or lowering the temperature.

What should the team do?

A Fine-tune a custom model on correct examples

B Lower the temperature to make the format stable

C Retry each call until the parser accepts it

D Structured outputs with a schema for the format

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the team do?

A Fine-tune a custom model on correct examples

Train a custom model.

B Lower the temperature to make the format stable

Turn a sampling dial.

C Retry each call until the parser accepts it

Accepts it, at extra cost.

D Structured outputs with a schema for the format

Variation managed by structure.

THE SIGNAL

Variation is a property. Structure and validation manage it; dials and training do not.

Module 33 in five lines

- **Read the ask first,** then the constraints; the clue is in the stem.
- **The qualifier decides** between workable options: first, best, cheapest, least effort.
- **Ten rules break ties;** eleven distractor families each fail one rule.
- **Choose two:** each pick right on its own; explain items reward the reason.
- **Pace:** about 2 min 15 s each, flag and return, answer every item.

> COMING UP
>
> Next: practice paper 1 - eighteen new questions across all eight domains.